

HESIOD

Works and Days
and
Theogony

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30 The other was born first though. Ebony Night
Bore her, and Kronos' son who sits high in thin air
Set her in Earth's roots, and she's a lot better for humans.
Even shiftless folks she gets stirred up to work.

When a person's lazing about and sees his neighbor
Getting rich, because he hurries to plow and plant
35 And put his homestead in order, he tends to compete
With that neighbor in a race to get rich.

Strife like this does people good.

40 So potter feuds with potter
And carpenter with carpenter,
Beggar is jealous of beggar
And poet of poet.

Now, Perses, you lay these things up in your heart
And don't let the mischief-loving Eris keep you from work,
Spending all your time in the market eyeballing quarrels
45 And listening to lawsuits. A person hasn't any business
Wasting time at the market unless he's got a year's supply
Of food put by, grain from Demeter out of the ground.
When you've got plenty of that, you can start squabbling
Over other people's money.

50 Not that you're going to get
Another chance with me. Let's settle this feud right now
With the best kind of judgment, a straight one from Zeus.
We had our inheritance all divided up, then you
Made off with most of it, playing up to those
55 Bribe-eating lords who love cases like this.
Damn fools. Don't know the half from the whole,
Or the real goodness in mallows and asphodel.

Why Life Is Hard

60 You know, the gods never have let on
How humans might make a living. Else,
You might get enough done in one day
To keep you fixed for a year without working.

You might just hang your plowshare up in the smoke,
And all the fieldwork done by your oxen
And hard-working mules would soon run to ruin.
But Zeus got his spleen up, and went and hid
65 How to make a living, all because shift Prometheus
Tricked him. That's why Zeus made life hard for humans.
He hid fire. But that fine son of Iapetos stole it
Right back out from under Zeus' nose, hiding
70 The flame in a fennel stalk. And thundering Zeus
Who rides herd on the clouds got angry and said:

"Iapetos' boy, if you're not the smartest of them all!
I bet you're glad you stole fire and outfoxed me.
But things will go hard for you and for humans after this.
I'm going to give them Evil in exchange for fire,
75 Their very own Evil to love and embrace."

That's what he said, the Father of gods and men,
And he laughed out loud. Then he called Hephaistos
And told him to hurry and knead some earth and water
80 And put a human voice in it, and some strength,
And to make the face like an immortal goddess' face
And the figure like a beautiful, desirable virgin's.
Then he told Athene to teach her embroidery & weaving,
And Aphrodite golden to spill grace on her head
85 And painful desire and knee-weakening anguish.
And he ordered the quicksilver messenger, Hermes,
To give her a bitchy mind and a cheating heart.
That's what he told them, and they listened to Lord Zeus,
Kronos' son. And right away famous old Gimpy
90 Plastered up some clay to look like a shy virgin
Just like Zeus wanted, and the Owl-Eyed Goddess
Got her all dressed up, and the Graces divine
And Lady Persuasion put some gold necklaces
On her skin, and the Seasons (with their long, fine hair)
95 Put on her head a crown of springtime flowers.
Pallas Athena put on the finishing touches,
And the quicksilver messenger put in her breast
Lies and wheedling words and a cheating heart,
Just like rumbling Zeus wanted. And the gods' own herald

100 Put a voice in her, and he named that woman
Pandora, because all the Olympians donated something,
And she was a real pain for human beings.

When this piece of irresistible bait was finished,
Zeus sent Hermes to take her to Epimetheus

105 As a present, and the speedy messenger-god did it.
Epimetheus didn't think on what Prometheus had told him,
Not to accept presents from Olympian Zeus but to send any
Right back, in case trouble should come of it to mortals.
No, Epimetheus took it, and after he had the trouble
110 Then he thought on it.

Because before that the human race
Had lived off the land without any trouble, no hard work,
No sickness or pain that the Fates give to men
(And when men are in misery they show their age quickly).

115 But the woman took the lid off the big jar with her hands
And scattered all the miseries that spell sorrow for men.
Only Hope was left there in the unbreakable container,
Stuck under the lip of the jar, and couldn't fly out:
The woman clamped the lid back on the jar first,
120 All by the plan of the Aegisholder, cloud-herding Zeus.
But ten thousand or so other horrors spread out among men,
The earth is full of evil things, and so's the sea.
Diseases wander around just as they please, by day and by night,
Soundlessly, since Zeus in his wisdom deprived them of voice.
125 There's just no way you can get around the mind of Zeus.

If you want, I can sum up another tale for you,
Neat as you please. The main point to remember
Is that gods and humans go back a long way together.

The Five Ages

Golden was the first race of articulate folk
130 Created by the immortals who live on Olympos.
They actually lived when Kronos was king of the sky,
And they lived like gods, not a care in their hearts,
Nothing to do with hard work or grief,
And miserable old age didn't exist for them.

From fingers to toes they never grew old, 135
And the good times rolled. And when they died
It was like sleep just ravelled them up.
They had everything good. The land bore them fruit
All on its own, and plenty of it too. Cheerful folk,
They did their work peaceably and in prosperity, 140
With plenty of flocks, and they were dear to the gods.
And sure when Earth covered over that generation
They turned into holy spirits, powers above ground,
Invisible wardens for the whole human race.
They roam all over the land, shrouded in mist, 145
Tending to justice, repaying criminal acts
And dispensing wealth. This is their royal honor.

Later, the Olympians made a second generation,
Silver this time, not nearly so fine as the first,
Not at all like the gold in either body or mind. 150
A child would be reared at his mother's side
A hundred years, just a big baby, playing at home.
And when they finally did grow up and come of age
They didn't live very long, and in pain at that,
Because of their lack of wits. They just could not stop 155
Hurting each other and could not bring themselves
To serve the Immortals, nor sacrifice at their altars
The way men ought to, wherever and whenever. So Zeus,
Kronos' son, got angry and did away with them
Because they weren't giving the Blessed Gods their honors. 160

And when Earth had covered over that generation—
Blessed underground mortals is what they are called,
Second in status, but still they have their honor—
Father Zeus created a third generation 165
Of articulate folk, Bronze this time, not like
The silver at all, made them out of ash trees,
Kind of monstrous and heavy, and all they cared about
Was fighting and war. They didn't eat any food at all.
They had this kind of hard, untameable spirit.
Shapeless hulks. Terrifically strong. Grapplehook hands 170
Grew out of their shoulders on thick stumps of arms,
And they had bronze weapons, bronze houses,

And their tools were bronze. No black iron back then.
 Finally they killed each other off with their own hands
 175 And went down into the bone-chilling halls of Hades
 And left no names behind. Astounding as they were,
 Black Death took them anyway, and they left the sun's light.

So Earth buried that generation too,
 And Zeus fashioned a fourth race
 180 To live off the land, juster and nobler,
 The divine race of **Heroes**, also called
 Demigods, the race before the present one.
 They all died fighting in the great wars,
 Some at seven-gated Thebes, Kadmos' land,
 185 In the struggle for Oidipous' cattle,
 And some, crossing the water in ships,
 Died at Troy, for the sake of beautiful Helen.
 And when Death's veil had covered them over
 Zeus granted them a life apart from other men,
 190 Settling them at the ends of the Earth.
 And there they live, free from all care,
 In the Isles of the Blest, by Ocean's deep stream,
 Blessed heroes for whom the life-giving Earth
 Bears sweet fruit ripening three times a year.

195 [Far from the Immortals, and Kronos is their king,
 For the Father of gods and men has released him
 And he still has among them the honor he deserves.
 Then the fifth generation: Broad-browed Zeus
 Made still another race of articulate folk
 200 To people the plentiful Earth.]

I wish

I had nothing to do with this fifth generation,
 Wish I had died before or been born after,
 Because this is the **Iron Age**.
 205 Not a day goes by
 A man doesn't have some kind of trouble.
 Nights too, just wearing him down. I mean
 The gods send us terrible pain and vexation.
 Still, there'll be some good mixed in with the evil,

And then Zeus will destroy this generation too, 210
 Soon as they start being born grey around the temples.
 Then fathers won't get along with their kids anymore,
 Nor guests with hosts, nor partner with partner,
 And brothers won't be friends, the way they used to be.
 Nobody'll honor their parents when they get old 215
 But they'll curse them and give them a hard time,
 Godless rascals, and never think about paying them back
 For all the trouble it was to raise them.
 They'll start taking justice into their own hands,
 Sacking each other's cities, no respect at all 220
 For the man who keeps his oaths, the good man,
 The just man. No, they'll keep all their praise
 For the wrongdoer, the man who is violence incarnate,
 And shame and justice will lie in their hands.
 Some good-for-nothing will hurt a decent man 225
 Slander him, and swear an oath on top of it.
 Envy will be everybody's constant companion,
 With her foul mouth and hateful face, relishing evil.
 And then

up to Olympos from the wide-pathed Earth, 230
 lovely apparitions wrapped in white veils,
 off to join the Immortals, abandoning humans
 There go **Shame** and **Nemesis**. And horrible suffering
 Will be left for mortal men, and no defense against evil.

And here's a fable for kings, who'll not need it explained: 235

It's what the hawk said high in the clouds
 As he carried off a speckle-throated nightingale
 Skewered on his talons. She complained something pitiful,
 And he made this high and mighty speech to her:
 "No sense in your crying. You're in the grip of real strength now, 240
 And you'll go where I take you, songbird or not.
 I'll make a meal of you if I want, or I might let you go.
 Only a fool struggles against his superiors.
 He not only gets beat, but humiliated as well."

Thus spoke the hawk, the windlord, his long wings beating. 245